MODULE 04 · FOUNDATIONS - ALL DOMAINS

Scrum in practice

Accountabilities, events, artefacts and commitments, and where a project manager fits in a framework that has no project manager.

DOMAIN Foundations EXAM WEIGHT All domains MODULE 04 of 49

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Scrum is deliberately incomplete. It gives **structure for learning**, not instructions for work.

Empiricism: three pillars

01

Transparency

The work and the process are visible to those doing and receiving it.

02

Inspection

Progress and artefacts are checked often, to spot problems early.

03

Adaptation

When something is off, the process or product is adjusted quickly.

ON THE EXAM

No transparency, no useful inspection. No inspection, no informed adaptation. Each pillar needs the one before.

The Scrum Team: three accountabilities

ACCOUNTABILITY	OWNS	DOES NOT OWN
Product owner	Maximising value; the product backlog and its order; the product goal	How the developers build it
Scrum master	The team's effectiveness; Scrum being understood and used well	Assigning tasks or managing people
Developers	The sprint backlog and plan; quality, meaning the definition of done	Product priorities

ON THE EXAM

One team, no hierarchy, typically ten people or fewer. Each accountability has a clear edge.

Product owner or scrum master?

PRODUCT OWNER

What and why

- Decides the order of the backlog
- Represents stakeholders' needs
- Clarifies items and their value
- One person, not a committee

SCRUM MASTER

How well the team works

- Coaches the team and the organisation
- Removes impediments
- Ensures events happen and stay useful
- A true leader who serves

THE TIEBREAKER

A priority question goes to the product owner. A process or impediment question goes to the scrum master.

The developers

- **Self-managing**: they decide internally who does what, when and how.
- **Cross-functional**: between them they have every skill needed to create value each sprint.
- Accountable for the **sprint backlog**, for meeting the definition of done, and for adapting their plan daily.
- 'Developers' means everyone doing the work: testers, designers, analysts. Not only programmers.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> An option where someone outside the developers assigns their tasks contradicts Scrum.

The sprint: a container for everything else

01

Sprint planning

Agree why, what and how for this sprint.

02

Daily scrum

Developers inspect progress to the goal.

03

The work

Build the increment; refine the backlog.

04

Sprint review

Inspect the outcome with stakeholders.

05

Retrospective

Inspect how the team worked; pick improvements.

ON THE EXAM

Sprints are fixed length, one month or less, and a new one starts as soon as the last ends.

Five events and their timeboxes

EVENT	MAX TIMEBOX (1-MONTH SPRINT)	PURPOSE
Sprint	1 month or less	Container for all the work
Sprint planning	8 hours	Sprint goal, items, plan
Daily scrum	15 minutes	Inspect progress, adapt the plan
Sprint review	4 hours	Inspect outcome with stakeholders
Retrospective	3 hours	Improve how the team works

ON THE EXAM

A timebox is a maximum. If the purpose is met early, the event ends early.

Sprint planning: three questions

- **Why is this sprint valuable?** The whole Scrum team agrees a sprint goal.
- **What can be done this sprint?** Developers select items, guided by their past performance and capacity.
- **How will the chosen work get done?** Developers plan it, often breaking items into small tasks.
- Nobody outside the developers decides how much work they take on.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The sprint goal is the commitment. The selected items are a forecast of how to reach it.

The daily scrum

- A **15-minute event for the developers**, at the same time and place each working day.
- Purpose: inspect progress towards the sprint goal, and adapt the plan for the next day.
- Not a status report to a manager, and not the only time the team talks.
- The Agile Practice Guide calls it, more generally, a **daily coordination meeting**.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If developers are reporting to someone rather than planning with each other, the daily scrum has been hijacked.

Sprint review or retrospective?

SPRINT REVIEW

Inspects the product

- What was achieved this sprint
- With key stakeholders present
- What to do next; backlog adapted
- A working session, not a gate

SPRINT RETROSPECTIVE

Inspects the process

- How the team worked
- The Scrum team only
- Most helpful changes identified
- Improvements may enter the next sprint

THE TIEBREAKER

Stakeholder feedback on the product: review. Team friction or process problems: retrospective.

Three artefacts, three commitments

ARTEFACT	WHAT IT IS	ITS COMMITMENT
Product backlog	The ordered list of what is needed to improve the product	Product goal: the long-term objective
Sprint backlog	The sprint goal, the items selected, and the plan to deliver them	Sprint goal: the single objective for the sprint
Increment	A usable step towards the product goal, added to all prior increments	Definition of done: the quality standard

ON THE EXAM

Work that does not meet the definition of done is not part of the increment. It returns to the product backlog.

Definition of done, or acceptance criteria?

DEFINITION OF DONE

One standard for everything

- Applies to every item and increment
- Quality: tested, reviewed, documented
- Owned by the Scrum team
- Set by the organisation if it has one

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

Specific to one item

- Written for one backlog item
- What this feature must do
- Agreed with the product owner
- Different for every item

THE TIEBREAKER

An item is finished only when it meets its own acceptance criteria AND the definition of done.

When the sprint meets reality

- Scope can be **clarified and renegotiated with the product owner** as the team learns.
- No changes that would **endanger the sprint goal**, and quality does not decrease.
- Only the **product owner can cancel a sprint**, and only if the sprint goal becomes obsolete.
- The sprint is never extended to finish work. Unfinished items go back to the product backlog.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> New ideas mid-sprint go to the product backlog. The current sprint changes only if the goal survives.

Backlog refinement

- An **ongoing activity**, not a formal Scrum event: items are broken down, detailed and sized.
- The **product owner** is accountable for the backlog; the **developers** size the work.
- Items near the top are small and clear enough to be **ready** for a sprint.
- Older material calls it 'grooming'. The Agile Practice Guide now uses 'refinement'.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Most sprint planning problems are really refinement problems that were left too late.

Five Scrum values

VALUE	LOOKS LIKE
Commitment	The team commits to its goals and to supporting each other
Focus	Attention stays on the sprint's work and the path to the goals
Openness	Work and challenges are made visible, not hidden
Respect	People respect each other as capable, independent professionals
Courage	Doing the right thing, and raising difficult problems

ON THE EXAM

Hiding a problem to look good in the review breaks openness and courage, whatever the short-term gain.

Where the project manager fits

- Scrum has **no project manager** accountability. Exam questions still say 'project manager' or 'project leader'.
- Inside a Scrum team, read that person as a **servant leader**: facilitating, coaching, removing impediments.
- Around the team: governance, budget, contracts, risks, stakeholders beyond the product, and other workstreams.
- Never: assigning developers' tasks, reordering the backlog, or deciding how much the team takes on.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> In an agile question, the PM serves the team and connects it to the organisation. They do not direct it.

Recognising Scrum going wrong

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN
Daily scrum is a status report	Developers plan together; status from boards
Several managers set priorities	One product owner orders one backlog
Sprint extended to finish work	Unfinished work returns to the backlog
Stakeholders task developers directly	Requests go to the product owner
Retros skipped: 'too busy'	Keep them: they fix the busyness

ON THE EXAM

Restore the Scrum rule, and do it by coaching, not by decree.

Project Lantern's app team in Scrum terms

- **Product owner:** Northgate's head of patient access. One person, backed by a clinic advisory group.
- **Scrum master:** an agile coach. **Developers:** seven people, including a tester and a UX designer.
- **Product goal:** patients book, move or cancel any appointment in under two minutes.
- The project manager runs the hybrid plan, the supplier contract and the steering committee, and never assigns app tasks.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Scrum inside, project management around it. That is how most hybrid exam scenarios are drawn.

A project manager has started attending a Scrum team's daily scrum. Each developer now reports yesterday's hours to the project manager, who asks follow-up questions.

The meeting regularly runs to forty minutes, and developers say they no longer use it to plan their day.

What should the project manager do?

A Enforce the fifteen-minute limit with a timer, keeping the updates brief.

B Replace the daily scrum with written status reports to save time.

C Return the daily scrum to the developers, and get status from the team's visible boards instead.

D Ask the scrum master's manager to take over running the meeting.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Enforce fifteen minutes.

Fixes the length but keeps the wrong purpose. It is still a status report.

B Replace it with written reports.

Removes the developers' daily planning, which is the whole point of the event.

C Give it back; use visible boards for status.

Restores the purpose and still meets the PM's need for information.

D Ask the scrum master's manager.

Escalates a problem the project manager created and can fix directly.

THE SIGNAL

The project manager caused the problem. The fix is to step back, not to tighten control.

> Two days before the end of a sprint, the developers realise one item will not pass performance testing, which is part of their definition of done.
>
> The product owner had hoped to demonstrate the feature to an important customer at the sprint review.

What should happen to the item?

A It is not included in the increment, and returns to the product backlog for the product owner to reorder.

B The sprint is extended by two days so the item can be finished.

C It is shown as done at the review, and performance is fixed next sprint.

D Performance testing is removed from the definition of done for this sprint.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should happen to the item?

A Not in the increment; back to the backlog.

Follows the definition of done and lets the product owner decide what comes next.

B Extend the sprint.

Sprints are fixed length. Extending them destroys the cadence and the forecast.

C Present it as done.

Breaks transparency and openness, and misleads the customer about quality.

D Drop the performance standard.

Lowers quality to hit a date. Quality does not decrease during a sprint.

THE SIGNAL

Undone means undone. Protect the definition of done and let the product owner re-plan.

> Halfway through a sprint to build a loyalty-points feature, the company announces it is closing the loyalty scheme at the end of the quarter.
>
> Everything in the current sprint is loyalty work. The developers ask the project leader what to do.

What should happen?

A The scrum master cancels the sprint and schedules a new one.

B The developers finish the sprint, because they committed to the work.

C The product owner may cancel the sprint, since its goal is now obsolete, and a new sprint is planned.

D The sponsor submits a change request to stop the loyalty work.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should happen?

A The scrum master cancels it.

Wrong person. Only the product owner has the authority to cancel a sprint.

B Finish the committed work.

The commitment is to the goal, and the goal no longer has any value.

C Product owner may cancel; plan anew.

An obsolete sprint goal is exactly when cancellation is allowed, by the product owner.

D Sponsor raises a change request.

Imports predictive change control into a framework with its own route.

THE SIGNAL

Sprint goal obsolete: the product owner may cancel. Nobody else can.

> A council's new digital services team is using Scrum. Five department heads jointly act as 'product owner', and each sends the developers their own priorities.
>
> The developers keep switching work, and little is finished in each sprint.

What should the project manager do?

A Let the developers choose which department's priorities to follow each sprint.

B Set the backlog order personally, to settle the disagreement.

C Escalate the conflict to the council's chief executive.

D Work with the sponsor and department heads to appoint one product owner who represents all of them.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Developers choose.

Hands a value decision to the people who should not own priorities.

B The PM sets the order.

The PM becomes a sixth voice and takes a decision that belongs to a product owner.

C Escalate to the chief executive.

Too high, too early. Nobody has yet tried to fix the structure with the sponsor.

D Agree one product owner who represents all.

Rung 3: collaborates to fix the root cause, a committee acting as product owner.

THE SIGNAL

Priorities from many voices must flow through one product owner. Fix the structure, not the symptoms.

> At a sprint review, a regional sales director sees the new ordering screen and asks for a bulk-upload option. It sounds valuable.
>
> She asks the developers to add it to the current sprint, which has four days left.

What should the project leader recommend?

A Add the feature to the current sprint, because stakeholder feedback is welcome.

B Capture it as a product backlog item for the product owner to order.

C Decline it as out of scope for the project.

D Submit it as a formal change request to the change control board.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader recommend?

A. Add it to this sprint.

Bypasses the product owner and threatens the current sprint goal.

B. Product backlog item for the PO.

Welcomes the feedback and routes it to the person who owns priorities.

C. Decline as out of scope.

Rejects valuable feedback. Adaptive scope expects new ideas like this.

D. Formal change request.

Predictive machinery. In Scrum the product backlog is the change mechanism.

THE SIGNAL

In Scrum, the product backlog is the change control. New ideas enter it; the product owner orders it.

> A new Scrum team has skipped its last three retrospectives because it felt too busy. The same build problems keep causing delays each sprint.
>
> Team members now describe the retrospective as a waste of time.

What should the project leader do?

A Stop scheduling retrospectives until the team is less busy.

B Identify the improvements personally and tell the team what to change.

C Coach the team on the retrospective's purpose, and facilitate a short one focused on the build problems.

D Report the team's non-compliance with Scrum to the PMO.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Stop retrospectives for now.

Removes the one event designed to fix the recurring problem.

B Tell the team what to change.

Takes improvement away from the team, so it will not own the changes.

C Coach, then a short, focused retrospective.

Rebuilds the habit by making it immediately useful on a real, painful problem.

D Report them to the PMO.

Compliance pressure, not coaching. Nobody has helped the team yet.

THE SIGNAL

A team too busy to improve stays busy. Show the retrospective's value on the problem that hurts most.

Priorities to the product owner. The work to the developers. The system to the scrum master.